

MAHADEO SEN



A Vote for DECAY

Another hung verdict means that one of India's richest states is destined to stagnate

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Shibu Soren may be 65 and no longer radiating the trademark vigour that once was customary to him. But, the old man in a hurry for Jharkhand's top job has proved his marksman skills once again. Though Guruji has not hit the bull's eye in the assembly polls, he is close enough. With 18 MLAs and no ideological baggage, the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) chief is closest of them all. Soren has appeared amiable, if not malleable to both the Congress and BJP by offering himself for the chief minister's post—the one he had to relinquish in January, following a bypoll defeat. Soren is very much aware that

Final Tally	
Regional players hold the key as voters reject national parties	
TOTAL SEATS	81
CONGRESS & JMM	25
BJP	18
JMM	18
RJD	5
JD(U)	2
OTHERS	13

he may be a bad salesman but the poll results have handed him a good product to put up on sale.

As the results poured in on December 23, there were shocks, surprises, optimism, celebrations and rallies for reconfiguration. Pundits and pollsters were left scurrying for cover, as they had predicted a clear verdict. There is just one certain possibility: the much-maligned Soren—the “dead horse” dumped by friends—could well emerge as the dark horse. His party has bagged 18 seats of the 81. Though it is just one more than what it bagged in 2005, the verdict hands over the key to the next state government to Guruji. He is at the centre of all permutations and combinations as no government